



from the Wright aircraft. They had a single propeller at the front and an elevator at the back, forming part of the tail with the rudder. Latham's mount was the supremely elegant Antoinette IV. Designed by Léon Levasseur, it perfectly fulfilled the French desire for a machine that would be an object of beauty as well as a functioning piece of

engineering. The Blériot XI was an altogether plainer machine, and also had a far less powerful engine than the Antoinette (see pages 42–43).

Crossing the Channel

The favorite to win the prize was Latham. Of Anglo-French descent, Latham was a wealthy

BLÉRIOT'S CHALLENGER

Hubert Latham's Antoinette IV is pictured being pushed across a field at Sangatte, France, just before Latham's first attempt to cross the English Channel on July 19, 1909.

playboy and adventurer who once gave his occupation as “man of the world.”

Sated with the excitements of big-game hunting, speedboat racing, and long-distance balloon flights, he had turned his attention to heavier-than-air flight in April 1909. Easy and confident, Latham was soon breaking speed and flight-duration records. The first to put his name forward for the cross-Channel prize, he arrived at Calais with Levasseur early in July.

The French navy agreed to provide a warship to accompany the flier across the sea. But it was the kind of summer with which residents of the Channel coasts are only too familiar: for days on end, wind and rain, cloud and mist kept Latham grounded. It was not until July 19 that a morning dawned with some hope of a break in the weather. Seizing his opportunity, Latham took off at 6:42 am, watched by a substantial crowd of journalists and admirers. One enraptured reporter described his “mechanical bird... diving into the light fog that blurred one's view of the uncertain horizon,” like a “new Icarus.” Too much like Icarus, it turned out. Latham had just flown over the top of the escorting French warship's funnels when his engine spluttered, coughed, and finally stopped altogether. He glided down to a smooth landing on the sea – the first ever made in an airplane. The French seamen sent to rescue the aviator found him sitting nonchalantly on his floating machine enjoying a cigarette.

Blériot's aircraft arrived at Calais on board the same train that brought Latham a replacement Antoinette from Paris. Blériot himself (see left) set up at Les Baraques, a farm not far from Sangatte. He was on crutches because of a severely burned foot (it had been doused with hot oil from his engine during a recent flight). His aircraft was also looking battered, but once it was unpacked, his mechanics set about assembling and repairing it. Meanwhile, the Comte de Lambert, at nearby Wissant, crashed while testing one of his Wright biplanes and was effectively out of the race. Once again the weather closed in. But in the early hours of the morning of Sunday, July 25, Blériot's team sensed a drop in the wind. Before dawn Blériot made a trial flight around Calais and found his machine in perfect working order. The French

LOUIS BLÉRIOT

LOUIS BLÉRIOT (1872–1936) was an engineer and skilled businessman who made his fortune in the automobile accessories business before turning his attention to flight. At the age of 28, he began his lifelong dedication to aviation by designing a flapping machine. By 1906 he was one of the most prominent French aeronautical experimenters, but his early aircraft designs were ungainly failures.

Gallantly supported by his adoring wife, who ran the business in his absence and cared for him after his frequent crashes, he stubbornly persisted. Although almost bankrupted by

A HOMAGE

The avant-garde painters who were revolutionizing art in the early 20th century admired aircraft as a symbol of modernity. Robert Delaunay, who painted this Hommage à Blériot (1914), had written to congratulate the aviator on his cross-Channel flight in 1909.



the expense of his experiments, he achieved a breakthrough in 1907 with the Blériot VII, a monoplane that flew 1,650ft (500m) and set the basic configuration for his Channel-hopping Blériot XI with its Anzani 25hp engine.

After the Reims meeting, Blériot stopped flying in deference to his wife's reasonable fears for his life – he was a remarkably accident-prone pilot even by the standards of the time. Blériot's future was assured by the huge demand for Blériot XI monoplanes that his spectacular flight generated. The Blériot Company would later produce the SPAD fighter flown by the Allies during World War I, and it was still a thriving business at the time of Blériot's death in 1936.

CHANNEL HOPPER

Louis Blériot was born in Cambrai, France, and achieved worldwide acclaim after becoming the first person to fly across the English Channel in a Blériot XI monoplane on July 25, 1909.

